

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Your Hurt Is Real

In February, somebody did something to Priya.

It was not a big somebody. It was not a big something. It was a small thing — the kind of thing that happens in a first-grade classroom every day, in every school, in every town, and that grown-ups usually miss, because grown-ups have stopped being able to see how big small things can be.

What happened was this. During morning meeting, the kids were playing a game where they had to find a partner. Ms. Calloway had said find a partner who has the same color sticker as you, and the kids had run around the carpet, looking for their match. Priya was a red sticker. The other red stickers were Jordan and a kid we have not really talked about yet named Theo.

Jordan got to Theo first. They high-fived.

Priya was left without a partner.

It was not on purpose. Jordan had not been mean to Priya. Jordan had simply seen Theo first and gotten there first, and there had only been three red stickers, and Priya had been the odd one out.

Ms. Calloway saw what had happened immediately. She paired Priya up with herself for the game, which Priya accepted, because what else are you supposed to do when you are six and your teacher says she will be your partner.

But for the rest of the day, Priya was a little quieter than usual. She did her work. She did not cry. She did not complain. She just got a little quieter.

When Ms. Calloway asked her at the end of the day if everything was okay, Priya said, "I am fine."

Ms. Calloway said, "Are you sure?"

Priya said, "It is okay. It was not that big a deal."

That night, when Priya was in bed, she thought about it.

She thought: It was not that big a deal.

She thought: I shouldn't be sad about it. Jordan didn't mean anything. She thought: I am being a baby.

These are exactly the wrong thoughts. They are the thoughts that small girls and small boys are trained to think when something happens that hurts a little but does not seem big enough to count. It was not that big a deal. I shouldn't be sad. I am being a baby.

The next morning, when Ms. Calloway took Sammy out of the box, Sammy said something that made Priya look up.

"Friends," said Sammy. "We are starting a new unit today. This unit is about other people. About when other people do things that hurt us. And the very first thing I want to say is —"

Sammy paused.

"— your hurt is real. Even if the other person did not mean it. Even if it was not on purpose. Even if it was a small thing. Even if everybody else has already forgotten about it. Your hurt is real. It counts. You are allowed to feel it."

Priya stared at Sammy.

"Some of you," said Sammy, "have been told, your whole short little lives, that you should not be sad about small things. It was not that big a deal. Get over it. It was just a joke. They did not mean it. I want to tell you, today, in this room, that those sentences are wrong."

"You are the one who knows if a thing hurt you. Nobody else. The size of the hurt is not measured by how the other person meant it. The size of the hurt is measured by how it landed inside you. If it landed big, it was big. If it landed small, it was small. Only you know."

"This is going to be a big idea for the rest of the year. So listen: the first step in forgiveness is naming the hurt. You cannot forgive what you have not named. You cannot put down what you do not admit you are carrying. You have to name it FIRST. And to name it, you have to give yourself permission to feel it."

Priya was sitting very still.

After the lesson, when the kids had gone off to do quiet work, Priya walked, very quietly, over to Ms. Calloway's desk.

"Ms. Calloway?"

"Yes, sweetheart?"

"Yesterday, when Jordan got to Theo first — I was sad. I told you I was fine but I was sad. I did not get a partner. I felt left out." Ms. Calloway put her pen down.

"Priya," she said. "Thank you for telling me. Your sadness about that is real. It is okay to have been sad. Even small things can land big. You are not being a baby for feeling it. You are being a person who is honest about her feelings."

Priya nodded.

"Do you want me to talk to Jordan?"

Priya thought about this for a second.

"No," she said. "I do not think he meant to. I think I just want to tell him I felt left out."

Ms. Calloway looked at her for a long moment.

"That is one of the most grown-up things I have ever heard a first-grader say."

Priya did, that day, at lunch, walk up to Jordan and say: "Jordan, when you got to Theo first yesterday and I did not have a partner, I felt left out. I do not think you did it on purpose. I just wanted to say." Jordan looked surprised. Jordan does not always understand emotional information in real time. He paused for a second and then said, "Oh. I am sorry, Priya. I did not see you. Next time we will find each other first, okay?"

"Okay," said Priya.

She walked back to her seat. She picked up her sandwich. Her chest felt a little lighter than it had felt at breakfast.

This is the beginning of forgiveness. Not forgiving someone in the big-dramatic-movie sense. Just naming the hurt out loud, to the person who caused it, in a clear and not-mean way, with the assumption that they did not mean to hurt you.

This is how grown-ups should also be doing this. Most grown-ups never learn. The lucky few who learn it, learn it from a first-grade teacher who happened to put a frog puppet on her hand on a Tuesday morning in February.